

Book Recommendation Hub — Project Brief (v2)

1. Overview

Goal: Help readers discover books they'll enjoy and encourage them to read more.

Target audience: Students, young readers, and anyone who enjoys reading or wants help choosing their next book.

One-line hook: "Discover books you'll love, read reviews, and track your reading journey!"

Headline: "Find Your Next Book!"

Trust/credibility angle: Built from personal frustration with having to browse a physical bookstore every time to find something new to read — a relatable, honest founder story rather than formal credentials.

2. Site Structure

Landing Page (public, no login required)

- Hero banner: photo collage of popular/well-known books
- Headline + 3-second explainer text
- "Get Started" button (primary CTA, placed below hero) → leads to signup
- About section: why the Book Recommendation Hub exists
- "Why Is Reading Important?" section: vocabulary, knowledge, imagination, relaxation benefits
- Entry point to browse/search books as a guest

Home (logged-in dashboard)

- Personalized hub reached after login/onboarding
- Quick access to Recommendations, Reviews, and Reading Tracker
- Distinct from the Landing Page — this is the "control center" for returning users

Navigation menu (consistent across the site)

Home · Search/Browse · Recommendations · Reviews · Reading Tracker · My Lists · Profile (*Recommendations, Reading Tracker, and My Lists prompt login if a guest clicks them.*)

3. Access Model

Action	Guest	Logged-in user
View landing page	✓	✓

Search/browse books, read reviews	✓	✓
View a book's detail page	✓	✓
Get personalised recommendations	✗ (prompt to sign up)	✓
Mark a book as Read/Currently Reading/Want to Read	✗ (prompt to sign up)	✓
Write a review	✗	✓
Request a missing book	✗	✓
Create/edit custom lists	✗	✓
View a shared public list link	✓	✓

No payments or booking system needed — the site is entirely free.

4. Signup & Onboarding Flow

1. Guest clicks "Get Started" (or is prompted after trying a login-only feature)
2. Creates an account with email + password
3. Immediately completes the onboarding survey (multiple choice + checkboxes):
 - **Favourite genre(s)** (select one or more): Fantasy, Romance, Mystery/Thriller, Adventure, Science Fiction, Horror, Historical Fiction, Realistic/Contemporary Fiction, Comedy/Humour, Non-fiction, Other
 - **Preferred book type**: Middle Grade, Young Adult, Adult
 - **Preferred length**: Short (<200pp), Medium (200–400pp), Long (400–600pp), Very long (600+pp), I don't mind
4. Clicks "Find My Perfect Book!" → lands on Home with personalised recommendations

Additional account features: password reset; survey answers should be editable later so recommendations can be refreshed.

5. Core Features

Recommendations

- Logic (v1): match books whose tags overlap with the user's survey answers (simple filter-based matching, not a weighted algorithm — keeps the first build manageable)
- Can revisit for a smarter/weighted version later

Reviews

- Star rating (1–5) + written text
- Public — visible to all visitors, including guests
- Users can edit their own reviews after posting

Book Detail Page

- A dedicated, SEO-optimised page per book (unique URL per title)
- Shows: book title, cover image, all reviews, tags/genres, star rating, and a short summary
- Interactive status button: mark as Read / Currently Reading / Want to Read directly from the page
 - Guests clicking this button are prompted to sign up/log in
- *Technical note for the build phase:* true SEO (so pages show up well in Google search) generally needs the site to render page content in a search-engine-friendly way — this is a build-stage decision, not something to worry about at the planning stage, but worth flagging to whoever builds it.

Reading Tracker

- Three default lists per user: Read, Currently Reading, Want to Read
- Logged-in only

Custom Reading Lists

- Logged-in users can create their own lists with a title of their choosing (e.g. “Favourite Fiction Reads”)
- A book can appear in a custom list independently of its status in the default tracker (Read/Currently Reading/Want to Read)
- Each list has a **Private/Public toggle**, set per list by the user:
 - **Private:** viewable only via the list’s share link
 - **Public:** visible on the user’s profile to anyone
- Shared list links are viewable by anyone, including guests with no account (read-only view — they cannot edit or add books)
- Users can edit, rename, reorder, or delete their own lists at any time

Search

- Any visitor (guest or logged-in) can search for a specific book
- Results show: summary, reviews/ratings, and tags matching the survey categories (e.g. Sci-Fi, Young Adult, 400-600 pages, Part of a Series)

Book Data Source

- Pulled automatically from an existing free book API (e.g. Google Books or Open Library) rather than manually maintained — reduces scope significantly for a first build

Request a Missing Book

- Simple form: logged-in users can submit a book they couldn’t find
 - v1: request is logged/emailed to the site owner for manual follow-up (no automated moderation queue yet)
-

6. User Stories

- As a non-logged-in user, I can access the landing page and browse/search books.
- As a new user, I can create an account with email + password and

- complete the onboarding survey to build my profile.
 - As a user, I can log in with email and password.
 - As a user, I can reset my password.
 - As a logged-in user, I can use the reading tracker to organise books into Read / Currently Reading / Want to Read.
 - As a logged-in user, I can write, edit, and leave a star rating and review on a book.
 - As a logged-in user, I can request that a missing book be added to the site.
 - As a logged-in user, I can get personalised recommendations based on my survey answers.
 - As a logged-in user, I can edit my survey answers to update my recommendations.
 - As any user (guest or logged-in), I can search for a book and see its summary, reviews, and tags.
 - As any user (guest or logged-in), I can view a book's dedicated page with its cover, summary, reviews, ratings, and tags.
 - As a logged-in user, I can mark a book as Read / Currently Reading / Want to Read directly from its book page.
 - As a logged-in user, I can create custom lists with my own titles and add books to them.
 - As a logged-in user, I can set a custom list to private or public.
 - As a logged-in user, I can share a link to one of my lists that anyone can view, even without an account.
 - As any user with a shared list link, I can view the list's books read-only.
-

7. Explicitly Out of Scope (v1)

- No online payments or booking calendar
 - No manual book database — relying on external API
 - No automated moderation/approval system for missing-book requests (manual for now)
 - No weighted/advanced recommendation algorithm (simple tag-matching only)
-

8. Open Questions for Later Iterations

- Should users be able to follow/see other users' reading lists (social features)?
- Should reviews support replies/comments, or stay as standalone reviews?
- Will there be an admin view eventually for managing missing-book requests?
- Any content moderation needed for reviews, given a younger audience?